

The Dhāraṇī of the Noble Avalokiteśvara of Eleven Faces

Ārya-Avalokiteśvara-ekādaśamukha-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 693 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སྐྱ་རས་གཟགིས་དབང་ཕྱུ་ཞལ་བཅ་གུཅགི་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའ་གི་ཟུངས།

Toh 693 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Avalokiteśvara-ekādaśamukha-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Phakpa Chenrezik Wangchuk Zhel Chungjikpa Zhejawé Zung, meaning "The Noble Avalokiteśvara of Eleven Faces." It belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur and presents a sacred mantra formula associated with Avalokiteśvara, the bodhisattva of compassion, in his eleven-faced form. The text is framed as a discourse in which Avalokiteśvara approaches the Buddha and proclaims this dhāraṇī — said to have been taught by an immeasurable number of buddhas — as a remedy capable of curing diseases, warding off evil and inauspiciousness, and dispelling bad dreams for the benefit of all sentient beings. As a dhāraṇī text, it belongs to a broad canonical genre concerned with the protective and liberating power of sacred verbal formulas, and it reflects the centrality of Avalokiteśvara's compassionate activity within the Mahāyāna tradition.

In the language of India: Ārya-Avalokiteśvara-ekādaśamukha-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The dhāraṇī called "The Noble Avalokiteśvara of Eleven Faces."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Avalokiteśvara, surrounded by many holders of vidyā mantras, went to where the Blessed One was. He bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated him three times, and sat to one side. He then addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, this essence-dhāraṇī known as 'Eleven Faces' was taught by one hundred and ten million buddhas. I shall proclaim it so that it may serve as medicine for all sentient beings and utterly pacify all diseases of the bile; so that it may avert all evil, all inauspiciousness, and all bad dreams; so that it may avert all untimely death; so that it may instill faith in those who have not yet entered the path; and so that it may utterly pacify obstructing spirits and harmful misleading influences.

Blessed One, through this essence-dhāraṇī one is protected, fully sheltered, fully upheld; one comes to be at peace and to enjoy wellbeing; one is freed

from punishment and freed from weapons; poison is neutralized. There is no one who can act as an opponent, and I have never seen, among this world together with its gods, its māras, its Brahmā, and its communities of renunciants and brahmins, anything that can harm one who holds this dhāraṇī — except the maturation of previous karma. This essence-dhāraṇī is praised and intended by all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Blessed One, all the Tathāgatas rejoice in this essence-dhāraṇī of mine.

Blessed One, I recall this: in the past, a number of kalpas ago equal to the grains of sand of the Ganges River, there appeared a Tathāgata named King of Light That Subdues Time, Arisen from the Bud of a Hundred Lotus Petals. I, being then a sage, received this dhāraṇī from that Tathāgata. The very moment I heard it, all the Tathāgatas of the ten directions became directly manifest before me, and I also attained the patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena. Thus I hold this essence-dhāraṇī dear. Therefore, a son or daughter of good family who is endowed with faith should venerate it with respect and recite this essence-dhāraṇī. One should recite it always, without letting the mind wander elsewhere. Rising in the morning and reciting it one hundred and eight times, one will, in this very life, come to fully hold ten qualities. What are the ten? One will be free of bilious disease; one will be fully upheld by all the Tathāgatas; without the need for great effort, one will find wealth, grain, and material goods; all enemies will be subdued and brought low; the royal hosts, even if they intend to speak harsh words, will change their minds; poison will be unable to take hold in the body; metallic poison will be unable to take hold; contagion will be unable to take hold; weapons will be unable to harm one; one will not meet a death caused by water; one will not meet a death caused by fire; and one will not meet a death caused by untimely passing.

Moreover, one will come to fully hold four additional qualities: at the time of death one will behold a Tathāgata; one will not be born in the lower realms; one will not meet a death caused by one's own stubbornness or ill-temper not yet relinquished; and after dying and passing from here, one will be born in the world-realm of Sukhāvatī.

Blessed One, I recall this:"

"From this present age, further back even than the time before ten Ganges-river-sands' worth of eons had passed, there appeared a Tathāgata called Fragrance of the Coral Tree. At that time, having taken hold of this

essence-dhāraṇī as a layperson, I turned back forty thousand eons of cyclic existence. And by drawing forth this essence, I obtained that bodhisattva liberation — the wisdom-essence called Entry into the Compassion of All Victors.

For all sentient beings who are bound by bonds, who are on the verge of bondage, and who are threatened by the afflictions of water, floods, and sufferings of every kind, may this essence of mine be their ground, their shelter, their refuge, and their ally. Even the hostile yakṣas and rākṣasas shall be drawn in by this essence and turned toward minds of loving-kindness and compassion, and I shall establish them in unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, so great is the miraculous power of this essence of mine. By reciting it even once, the four root downfalls shall be purified; even the five acts of immediate retribution shall without exception be cleansed. What need is there to speak, then, of practising it diligently as has been described? For those will generate roots of virtue before many hundreds of thousands of millions of buddhas. And what need is there to speak of reciting and accomplishing it? All aspirations shall be completely fulfilled just as one desires.

If anyone, for my sake, observes the fast on the fourteenth or fifteenth of the month, that person will turn back forty thousand eons of cyclic existence. Blessed One, it is meaningful to hold my name — it surpasses even a hundred thousand million buddhas. All sentient beings who hold my name shall be established in irreversibility; they shall be entirely freed from all illness; they shall be entirely freed from all obscurations and all misconduct of body, speech, and mind.

For those who perform the ritual in the proper manner, they shall in due course obtain the awakening of a buddha."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, how great is your compassion for all sentient beings! Noble son, through this skillful means you are able to establish all sentient beings in unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. And yet, holding this essence and rejoicing in it — noble son, please speak."

Then the great bodhisattva, the noble Avalokiteśvara, rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, bowed his head to the feet of the Blessed One, and recited this essence:

Namo ratnatrayāya. Namō ārya-jñānasāgara-vairocana-vyūharājāya
tathāgatāya arhate samyaksaṃbuddhāya. Namaḥ sarvatathāgatebhyaḥ
arhatebhyaḥ samyaksaṃbuddhebhyaḥ. Namō ārya-avalokiteśvarāya
bodhisattvāya mahāsattvāya mahākāruṇikāya. Tadyathā: oṃ dhara dhara
dhiri dhiri dhuru dhuru iṭṭe vaṭṭe cale cale pracale pracale kusume kusuma
vare ili mili citi jvala māpanaya svāhā.

The ritual of this essence requires no elaborate accomplishment practice; it accomplishes all purposes. Muddy water should be praised by reciting the essence and then applied by anointing it upon fevers lasting one day, two days, three days, or four days; upon elemental spirits, ḍākinīs, ghosts, and corpse-animating spirits; upon the bewildering spirit of forgetfulness; upon itching skin; upon rashes of measles; upon diseases of the lymph nodes and the like; upon poisons; upon eyes struck by evil gaze; upon psoriasis and similar conditions.

If it is recited seven times, it will purify karmic obscurations. For a child seized by a possessing spirit, grain flour is the remedy. For an ear afflicted with festering discharge, costus root and grain flour are the remedy.

For a nose afflicted with festering discharge, grain flour applied to it will bring relief. It may also be applied to all festering ailments, and the recitation will accomplish the cure.

Here ends the dhāraṇī called "The Noble Avalokiteśvara of Eleven Faces."

Translated by the Indian master Śīlendrabodhi and —

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered "King of Light That Subdues Time, Arisen from the Bud of a Hundred Lotus Petals" translates the Tathāgata name "Padma-brgya'i spyan gtsug gis chags pa'i dus 'joms pa'i 'od zer gyi rgyal po." The compound is somewhat unusual and its Sanskrit reconstruction is not fully certain; the rendering given follows the Tibetan closely.

The phrase "ya nga ba ma spangs pa" rendered "stubbornness or ill-temper not yet relinquished" refers to dying in a state of agitation or petulance, a condition that prevents a good death; the exact nuance of the term in this context is noted here for completeness.

The text breaks off with "Blessed One, I recall this," which is the standard formula reintroducing a further recollection; the passage as given ends here.

- The term rendered "Fragrance of the Coral Tree" translates the Sanskrit name Mandāravapuṣpa-gandha, here abbreviated in the Tibetan as Mandāra-bsuṅ — the Tathāgata whose name means the fragrance of the mandāra flower, the coral or erythrina blossom, one of the flowers of the divine realms.

The phrase rendered "acts of immediate retribution" refers to the five ānantarya-karmas, the five most severe negative acts that bring immediate karmic consequence at death: killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and causing schism in the Saṅgha.

The ailments listed toward the end of the passage present genuine philological difficulty. Several terms are rare medical or demonological terms in classical Tibetan, and their precise identification is uncertain. The rendering given follows the most plausible traditional identifications, but specialists in Tibetan medical vocabulary may differ.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the colophon, naming only the first translator (Śīlendrabodhi). The second name, typically a Tibetan lotsāwa collaborator, follows in the next passage and is not present here.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.